

Obituary for Jörg Schönert (1941–2026)

Jörg Schönert's career as a scholar of German literature spanned 57 years. His research topics ranged from historical studies of the Enlightenment, with a focus on 18th-century satire, to crime fiction and 20th-century theatre; his expertise also included theoretical and conceptual approaches to the social history of literature, as well as systematic and historical narratology. In addition to research on the history of scholarship and the discipline of literary studies – which he pursued both as a historical enterprise and with an eye to current developments – he also expressed concern for the concrete career prospects of students in German Studies.

For our journal, his work in the field of theory and methodology is particularly relevant. Jörg Schönert's long-standing engagement with social-historical theory and practice stemmed from his involvement in the DFG-funded Munich Research Unit »Social History of German Literature 1770–1900«. Within this context, he developed a far-reaching theoretical framework that models, amongst other things, the relationship between literature and society in a systematic and theoretically ambitious manner. In this regard, Jörg Schönert's theoretical concerns were closely linked to an interest in improving the analysis and interpretation of literary texts. This interplay is clearly evident in the thematically diverse contributions, published between 1983 and 2001, that were later collected in the volume *Perspectives on the Social History of Literature* [in the original German, *Perspektiven zur Sozialgeschichte der Literatur*] (2007).

Another major contribution to German-language literary theory is the volume *Approaches to Literature and Literary History: Positions and Perspectives after the ›Theory Debate‹* [in the original, *Vom Umgang mit Literatur und Literaturgeschichte: Positionen und Perspektiven nach der ›Theoriedebatte‹*] (1991), which Jörg Schönert co-edited with Lutz Danneberg, Friedrich Vollhardt, and Hartmut Böhme. Bringing together a substantial number of outstanding and widely cited contributions, the volume fuelled debates on the concepts of text and interpretation, as well as the writing of literary historiography. The volume on the DFG symposium of the same name, *Literary Studies and Scientific Research* [in the original, *Literaturwissenschaft und Wissenschaftsforschung*] (2000), edited and overseen by Jörg Schönert, further developed the field conceptually. This work argues for making broader research questions and methodologies applicable to literary studies, and, thereby, advancing the discipline's methodological standards and its

capacity for self-reflection. The importance he attached to reflecting upon and upholding academic standards was evident not only in his publications on these topics, but also in the conscientiousness with which he carried out his duties as a reviewer over many years and in a wide variety of contexts.

Jörg Schönert also played a significant role in the rapid development of narratology in the German-speaking world, particularly through his involvement in the interdisciplinary research group »Narratology« and in its publications, which have had an impact far beyond Hamburg, where the group was founded. In his contributions to narratology, he brought together theory and methodology, both from an intercultural perspective (2004, with Magdolna Orosz) and through his proposal to modernise the study of lyric poetry by critically adopting narratological categories with a genre-specific focus (2007, with Peter Hühn). The current resurgence of lyric studies has been shaped in no small measure by an occasionally critical engagement with this proposal.

All of Jörg Schönert's publications attest to his rigorous rationality and his aversion to passing intellectual fads. He was a firm believer in the persuasive force of sound arguments and had little need for rhetorical flourish or terminological excess. His work consistently exemplifies the philological virtues of thoroughness, meticulous and judicious research, and clear lines of argumentation. As a result, regardless of subject, he produced works that, even years after their first publication, have become standard references that continue to yield illuminating insights. Above all, collaborations such as those mentioned above demonstrate, in conviction and in practice, that Jörg Schönert was an exemplary colleague and collaborator, a real team player.

Jörg Schönert passed away unexpectedly on 18 May 2026. With his passing, German-language literary studies has lost one of its most influential figures, and the *JLT* has lost a long-standing and exceptionally reliable member of its advisory board, and not least a mentor and friend.